

Capstone 2026-27: Authoritarianism theme

Theme-group outline — Dr Noah Buckley

24 September 2026

Credits	20 ECTS
Theme instructor	Dr Noah Buckley — noah.buckley@tcd.ie
Workshops	Thursdays 09:00–11:00 , fortnightly · Arts Building 5085 · first on 24 September
Coordinators	Dr Matthias Dilling (Michaelmas) · Dr Liam Kneafsey (Hilary)
Dissertation due	Wednesday 24 March 2027, 4pm (8,000 words max)
Podcast due	Friday 9 April 2027, 5pm
Assessment	Participation 10% · short submissions 15% · dissertation 65% · podcast 10% · research proposal formative
Research guide	noahbuckley.me/teaching/research-guide

This outline complements the department's **Overall Capstone Document 2026-27** on Blackboard. The Overall Document is the final word on word limits, house style, late penalties, ethics and the rules for being allowed to submit; this one tells you how *our* group works and when things are due.

1. The theme

You can study one authoritarian state in the present or recent past, compare two non-democracies, or use quantitative methods to compare across authoritarian systems. Topics include non-democratic institutions, the strategies of lesser-studied regimes, ideology, surveillance and information control, transitions (e.g. Myanmar, Venezuela), and the role of external actors.

Quantitative data on authoritarian elites, public opinion, economic performance and institutions is available, and **I will strongly encourage using it** — no one needs to be an R expert already, and I will help. Careful qualitative work is equally welcome. What matters is that the project is new, interesting, feasible, narrow, and *political science* rather than a report; we discuss these criteria in the first workshop.

2. How the group works

Fortnightly two-hour workshops develop *your* independent research project: you present, get feedback from me and each other, act as discussant for someone else, and leave with a clearer next step. Between workshops you do the work.

- **Come prepared and contribute.** Read what is assigned — academic readings early on, each other’s drafts later. Participation is assessed; I record attendance and contribution at every workshop.
- **This is your project.** I can offer leads, advice, and course corrections.
- **One-to-one supervision is not part of this module.** All supervision happens in workshops and clinics.

Clinics

Clinics are drop-in “group office hours” for concrete problems: your data, your R code, a paragraph that will not come right, a dataset you cannot find. These will be held in HT, dates TBA.

3. Michaelmas Term schedule

Workshop	Teaching week	Date	Topic	Due beforehand
1	2	Thu 24 Sep	Getting started	Readings in §6
2	4	Thu 8 Oct	Three potential research questions	Three questions, Tue 6 Oct, 5pm
3	6	Thu 22 Oct	Final research question	Final question, Tue 20 Oct, 5pm
4	8	Thu 5 Nov	Literature and research design (swap-and-explain exercise)	Annotated bibliography, Tue 3 Nov, 5pm
5	10	Thu 19 Nov	Three potential methodologies; proposal Q&A	Three methodologies, Tue 17 Nov, 5pm
—	—	Fri 11 Dec	—	Research proposal, 5pm

Presentation files (PowerPoint or PDF) go into the group’s OneDrive folder (link on Blackboard) by 8:40 on the morning of the workshop. Written submissions go to Turnitin in our theme area on Blackboard.

4. Assessment

The weights and the rules are set by the Overall Capstone Document; this section says what each piece looks like in our group.

Participation (10%)

Attend every workshop, engage with the material, present your own work at each stage, and act as a formal discussant for a classmate in Hilary Term. Unexcused absences reduce this mark. **You must attend at least two workshops in each term to be permitted to submit a dissertation.**

Short submissions (15%)

Four short pieces, each feeding the next, presented briefly in the following workshop. Word limits carry a 10% tolerance either way; outside that range costs up to 5 marks. Make each one as useful *to you* as you can.

#	Submission	Weight	Words	Due
1	Three potential research questions	2.5%	400–500 total	Tue 6 Oct, 5pm
2	Final research question	2.5%	500	Tue 20 Oct, 5pm
3	Annotated bibliography	5%	500	Tue 3 Nov, 5pm
4	Three potential methodologies	5%	500	Tue 17 Nov, 5pm

Full specs, and what a good one looks like, are in the [short-submissions sheet](#).

Research proposal (formative; compulsory)

1,500 words, due **Friday 11 December, 5pm**. Not marked, but you must submit it to be allowed to submit the dissertation, and you will get detailed written feedback. Include an introduction (topic, social and scholarly significance), a literature review, the variation to be explained, the main posited explanation(s), and the methodological strategy. You will work from this over the Christmas break — and you will need to.

Dissertation (65%)

The final research project: **8,000 words maximum**, due **Wednesday 24 March 2027 at 4pm** via Turnitin. This limit is the department's, not mine, and there is no tolerance on it — 10 marks deducted if exceeded — and a successful project is unlikely to be shorter than 7,500. Word count includes text and footnotes; excludes title page, abstract, acknowledgments, table of contents, tables, appendices and bibliography. House style: title page, abstract, table of contents, alphabetical bibliography, precise word count, and the School Assignment Submission Form as first page. Late work: 5 marks per day or part thereof; nothing accepted after Monday of Hilary

teaching week 12.

Podcast (10%)

A 5–8 minute audio podcast explaining your project to a general audience — the question, why it matters, what others have found, your explanation, your findings and what they mean — due **Friday 9 April 2027, 5pm**. Assessed on substance and structure, not production values; any recording software is fine. If you can explain your dependent variable to a parent or friend with no political science, you are most of the way there.

5. Hilary Term (details confirmed in January)

Four workshops, Thursdays 09:00–11:00, room to be confirmed:

Workshop	Teaching week	Date	What happens
6	2	Thu 28 Jan	Progress check-in — bring draft material.
7	4	Thu 11 Feb	Work-in-progress presentations + discussant, group A.
8	6	Thu 25 Feb	Same, group B.
—	7	—	Reading week (teaching week 7), w/c 1 Mar. No formal feedback on drafts after this point.
9	11	Thu 1 Apr	After submission: the podcast, and what comes next. Date to be confirmed.

Presenters circulate a written draft (at minimum the introduction, ideally much more) by the Tuesday evening before they present. Submitting draft material in Hilary Term, as agreed with me, is — like the research proposal — a condition of being allowed to submit a dissertation. Guidance for presenting and for being a discussant is in the [presenting-and-discussing sheet](#). Clinics run in the in-between weeks until reading week; an optional R refresher is offered early in the term (to be confirmed).

Eight weeks from the first HT workshop to the deadline goes very fast, and if you leave data collection or analysis to the last minute and need help, I may not be able to give it. Collect your data by the end of January; have preliminary results ready when you present.

6. Readings

For workshop 1, look at these and come with reactions: what you liked, what you did not, ideas they sparked. You do not have to read every word.

Recommended

- Milan Svolik. 2012. *The Politics of Authoritarian Rule*. Cambridge University Press. Chapter 1.
- Andreas Schedler. 2002. “[The Menu of Manipulation](#).” *Journal of Democracy* 13(2): 36–50.

Also recommended

- Beatriz Magaloni. 2006. *Voting for Autocracy*. Cambridge University Press. Introduction and two chapters of your choice from 2–8.
- Sheena Chestnut Greitens. 2016. *Dictators and their Secret Police*. Cambridge University Press. Selected pages.
- Quintin H. Beazer, Noah Buckley and Ora John Reuter. 2026. “[The Demand for Elections under Autocracy: Regime Approval and the Elimination of Local Elections in Russia](#).” *American Journal of Political Science*.

Research design (all year; the first two are on Blackboard)

- Alan Bryman. 2016. *Social Research Methods*. Oxford University Press.
- John Gerring. 2012. *Social Science Methodology: A Unified Framework*. Cambridge University Press.
- Paul M. Kellstedt and Guy D. Whitten. 2018. *The Fundamentals of Political Science Research*. 3rd ed. Cambridge University Press.
- Charles Lipson. 2005. *How to Write a BA Thesis*. University of Chicago Press.
- Gary King, Robert O. Keohane and Sidney Verba. 1994. *Designing Social Inquiry*. Princeton University Press.

And the [research guide](#): the pitfalls I see every year, collected in one place.

7. Ethics approval

Research involving human participants (interviews, surveys, participant observation, experiments) needs approval from the Department of Political Science *before* data collection, and the review takes weeks. Retrospective approval is not possible. If you might collect original data from people, tell me at workshop 2 or 3 at the latest and **apply by December** (January in exceptional circumstances). Approval is not guaranteed, so have a back-up plan. Secondary analysis of existing data does not need clearance. Most projects in this group will not need it.

8. Academic integrity

Plagiarism is a serious offence, and undisclosed AI-generated text counts. See the Library guide: libguides.tcd.ie/academic-integrity.

Generative AI

These tools exist, you use them, and you will use them in whatever you do after this degree. What this module assesses is whether *you* can ask a question, design a way to answer it, and write up what you found. So the line is: use these tools to help you think, to help you code, and to help you fix prose you wrote; do not use them to do the thinking or produce the prose. What is permitted for each piece of work will use the vocabulary of the School Assignment Submission Form. “Permitted” means you may do it and must tick the corresponding box on the form. “Not permitted” means doing it is an academic integrity matter, whether or not you disclose it.

The rules for GenAI in the capstone will be provided per assignment. Dissertation rules TBA.

The Assignment Submission Form

Must be attached as the first page of every written submission (short submissions, proposal, dissertation), completed in full including the plagiarism declaration and the GenAI disclosure. Work without a form is not accepted and accrues late penalties until it is resubmitted with one.

9. Other things

- **Late work and extensions.** 5 marks per day or part thereof. Requests for exemption (medical certificate, LENS report, other) must go through your College Tutor *before* the deadline; late or after-the-fact requests are not accepted.
- **Problems.** Talk to me first. If that does not resolve it, contact the Capstone Coordinator (Dr Dilling in Michaelmas, Dr Kneafsey in Hilary).
- **Support.** Student Learning Development (tcd.ie/sld), the Library’s subject librarians for finding literature and data, and the Disability Service for LENS reports.